batsman of the 1970s and 1980s. I could hardly believe that he wanted to speak to me.

'You are changing the game,' he said.

I smiled, unsure of what to say.

'I'm serious. You're changing the way this game is played. People used to say the same about me many years ago, but I am saying it to you now. You are taking cricket to a new level. Keep going.'

Feeling overwhelmed, I thanked him and tried to change the subject.

RCB started the 2013 tournament in outstanding form, winning six of our first eight matches, but we then lost four out of six consecutive matches on the road. As ever, there were some great occasions, like the evening at Chinnaswamy when we beat Pune Warriors by 130 runs after Chris scored a staggering 175 from 66 balls. However, yet again, we finished fifth and, yet again, we just failed to qualify for the play-offs.

With another cycle of three-year contracts coming to an end, RCB then exercised its option to contract Virat, Chris and me as three of the five players that every team was entitled to retain and effectively keep out of the player auction, which was held in February 2014.

The opening 20 matches of IPL 7 in 2014 were played in the United Arab Emirates amid renewed concerns over security during the general election in India. We won two and lost two matches in the UAE, resumed the tournament in India and remained inconsistent: brilliant one day, pretty average the next.

We finished seventh in the eight-team league in 2014, winning only five of our 14 matches. I was typically being asked to bat at four or five, held back as a kind of safety net to keep us in the game if we happened to lose early wickets. As a result, more often than not, I would come in around the 15th or 16th over and my opportunity to impact the match would be limited to scoring something like a quick 30 off 15 balls.

In an ideal world, I would have preferred to bat in the top three and to have had the opportunity to play a major innings but, in the interests of